I have called this book *Coromandel* chiefly for sentimental reasons. I first became aware of that sonorous word as a fifteen-year-old schoolboy exiled in England. *Coromandel!* was the title of the third in a series of *Boy's Own*-style adventure stories set in India written by John Masters, an ex-Indian Army officer turned popular novelist. It was all about a West Country lad who sails to India with a map to find the legendary Coromandel and make his fortune. I reread it recently and found it not half as good as I thought it was – but the magic of that word Coromandel has always stayed with me, as the very essence of South India in all its elusiveness and allure. I'm not alone in thinking this. The French fashion-house Chanel markets a perfume it calls Coromandel which, it claims, 'unfurls the enveloping notes of its amber vibrato before giving way to a lingering voluptuous accord'. It lists the perfume's ingredients as frankincense, benzoin and patchouli. If it were up to me, those ingredients would be sandalwood, nutmeg, cinnamon and cloves, with a touch of pepper and cardamom to give it added spice.

Supporters of the late Edward Said, whose book *Orientalism* caused a mighty rumpus when it was published in 1978, would call such sentiments typically Orientalist, but I would refer them to the Bengali writer-in-exile Nirad Chaudhuri, who in his book *The Continent of Circe* (1965) compared Mother India to the Greek sorceress Circe, who seduced men with her enchantments and kept them trapped on her island. That is rather how I feel about India, the land of my birth. Ever since I can remember I have been immersing myself in her muddy waters, getting her dust between my toes. Almost my earliest memory is of lurching on elephant-back through steamy sub-tropical jungle, my father having borrowed a couple of elephants from a local maharaja to go in search of a legendary copper temple lost in the jungles of northeastern Assam. I remember losing my sola (note spelling!) topee, which in those days was